



Panasonic VDR-D160

Basic, Painfully So!

Sporting a bright silver and dull grey colour tone, the VDR-D160 is compact for a Mini DVD camcorder. The sticker on the side sporting the 30X optical zoom moniker puts across a subtle statement rather than screaming style. Build quality is extremely good—even the slightest play from the Mini DVD drive bay after two weeks of usage. Even the outer surface treatment seems excellent—well-set to weather the passing of time.

If anything, we found ergonomics even better than that of the SDR-H20, which we'll harp about a little later. The Record button is a little closer to one's hand than on the bulkier HDD-based SDR-H20, as a result of which large-hand-

ed people will find their index finger and thumb getting cramped. If you've got smaller hands—perfect! The joystick has a nice positive feedback and works well. The simple menu is well complemented by the easy one-handed operation—others should take note of the way Panasonic has worked on usability; you never need stop shooting to access any of the menus. The SD card bay lock seems a little cheaply built, not like the SDR-H20.

Immediately, we noticed slight graininess while shooting indoors—there was noise that became apparent especially at the long end of the zoom. The IS system does work at up to 15x magnification, but at 25x and beyond, you'll notice small jitters—something which we couldn't notice on the SDR-H20. However, outdoors, with better natural lighting, this won't be a problem—and you'll hardly ever use the entire zoom indoors.

At rupees 19,990 the Panasonic VDR-D160 quickly establishes itself as an alternative to the Canon DC210 and the Samsung VP-D975Wi and while we can easily recommend it over the latter it gets neck and neck with the former. Of course danger from the excellent value for money

Sony DCR-DVD608E is ever present.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD image sensor (0.4 megapixel); LCD viewfinder 2.5-inches (105,000 pixels); Weight: 480 gm

RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7
Ergonomics	: 7.5
IS effectiveness	: 6
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 5.5
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 7
Photo Quality	: 5.5
Audio quality	: 7.5

Panasonic VDR-D220

A Functional Performer

This one, the bigger brother to the VDR-D160, looks very similar and shares the subtle look that attracts without really meaning to. Beauty is in the detailing and the fine body sculpting here—Panasonic wins hands down in that department. Build quality is top-notch, something else the siblings share—once again, two weeks and never a creak could we get out of her.

The VDR-D220 has double the megapixel rating and also foregoes the cheaper Digital Image Stabilisation for the more effective Optical IS. However, the image sensor is very much the same at 1 / 6-inch—typical consumer stuff.

Sharing the same sensor should mean very similar performance—and it's easy to spot. There is noticeable graininess when shooting indoors, but to be honest, you're always going to encounter such issues with single CCD sensor camcorders. Noise is something we've become accustomed to indoors, and we found quite a good deal; once you're shooting in the bright sun, these niggles disappear. At the long end of the zoom, we found some minor issues with focusing: the VDR-D220 isn't as fast at getting into focus as is the Panasonic SDR-H20 or the Canon DC51. However, the optical IS system proves its mettle—it's marginally better than the VDR-D160 in this regard, though miles behind its HDD-



media-based sibling.

At a price of rupees 21,990, the Panasonic VDR-D220 makes a good buy—its better than the cheaper models, and has a good IS system. Highly recommend for its price.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD image sensor (0.8 megapixel); LCD viewfinder 2.7-inches (123,000 pixels); Weight: 510 gm

RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7
Ergonomics	: 7.5
IS effectiveness	: 6
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 5.5
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 7
Photo Quality	: 5.5
Audio quality	: 7.5